

▲ By The Way...

Some applications show all the files in a directory, but the ones the program can't open are dimmed so you can't select them. You can only select files that are displayed in black.

Let's open the "Read.Me" file. This document tells you who in the System 6 development team did what. First, click the Read.Me file; then click the Open button. The file will be opened and displayed on your screen, and Teach will be ready for you to read or edit it.

The Open button has a double border, making it the default button, so we could have simply pressed Return to open the file once we'd selected it. (Most applications also accept ⌘-O to trigger the Open button.) Or we could simply have double-clicked the file we wanted to open. There's a Cancel button there, too, which obviously would dismiss the Open dialog without opening any file (you can also use its key equivalent, ⌘-Period.)

Instead of clicking the file we wanted to open, we could have used the up and down arrow keys to select it. We could even have typed the first letter of the file's name, and the black bar would have jumped immediately to the first file in the list that starts with that name. In fact, you can type the first *several* characters of the file's name (as long as you type them quickly enough) and the black bar will jump to the first file starting with the letters you type.

For now, make no changes to the "Read.Me" file. Just close it. (You can click the close box in the upper left corner of the window, or use the "Close" option on the File menu or its key equivalent.) Now bring up the Open dialog again—we'll take a look at some of the other features of the Standard File dialog.

Let's look inside a folder. Double-click the System folder. Not surprisingly, there are no files in the System folder that Teach knows how to open, so you just see a lot of folders. Double-click the Sounds folder to look in there. Nope, no openable files there. Click the Close button (or press Escape) to move back upward through the hierarchy to the System folder, then double-click the Fonts folder. Disappointment—no openable files there either. (There aren't any files on the SystemTools2 disk that Teach can open other than the two in the main directory.)

Press the downward-pointing triangle next to the disk name to access the pop-up folder menu. This menu shows you how deep in a disk you are, starting with the current directory and working backward through parent directories to the disk name. In our case, we see the Fonts folder, the System folder, the disk's main directory, and, curiously, a level called "Desktop."

From this pop-up menu, you can select any directory in the hierarchy and the Standard File dialog will immediately display the contents of the directory. For example, we could select "SystemTools2" and immediately "pop back" to that directory. It should be becoming clear that the Standard File dialog represents your disk's directories in a sort of "flattened" fashion. (In Standard File, unlike the Finder, you see only one directory at a time.)

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If it helps, think of the Standard File directory as having built-in tunneling. When you open a new folder, the old one is automatically closed.